

to see him, I heard a titter of laughter all over the place. Finally his secretary consented to let me see Mr. Edison. As soon as I faced the great inventor I started telling him how fortunate he was that I was giving him the first chance at my services. After I'd talked a while, he rose, walked all around me, looked me over with penetrating eyes, grinned and asked: "What did you come to see me about, young man?"

"That's how I discovered he was hard of hearing. Now I had to explain myself all over, loudly. My clothes were wrinkled and dusty, my shoes were scuffed, I had a two days' growth of beard, and I almost lost my courage. It is to Mr. Edison's credit that he did not judge me by my appearance. But I made up my mind, then and there, that never again would I stand before any man without knowing that I was better dressed than he.

"Now you see why I have all these clothes. And as far as my giving you my discards is concerned, I doubt if you would get from them the same ego boost they give me."

He was right. I never have felt the need to bolster my ego by personal adornment, and I too am right, for ego is a strictly personal matter. During the early part of my career I did stimulate my ego with that large estate and those elegant cars. Later, when my work became widely accepted, I became content with a much simpler style of living. Yet I do not neglect my ego, which functions through my Princes of Guidance.

Still, just like Mr. Barnes and so many others, I see myself reflecting long-ago experiences which I no longer wish to suffer. During my childhood I lived amid poverty and illiteracy, surrounded by poverty-stricken neighbors. Now I am very sensitive to the "feel" of any neighborhood in which I live, and it must be just right. I even inspect the approaches to my home to make sure they do not lead through any unpleasant areas.

You may find it instructive to look back at the early influences of your own life and see how much they may have to do with your actions now. Here are some questions to get you started. Think a while after each to make sure you have found the right answer.

As a child . . .

Did you have sufficient food, clothing and shelter?

If the answer is *No*; was it insufficient by any reasonable